

UP Is Getting a New Identity as India's Growth Engine

Minister for Industries Nand Gopal Gupta on how the state worked on areas such as labour regulation and land administration to make the state business-friendly

BY AISHWARYA PATIL

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NAND GOPAL GUPTA, the industrial development, export promotion, NRI and investment promotion minister of Uttar Pradesh (UP), has his agenda set as the state pursues its ambitious goal of becoming a \$1-trillion economy by 2029-30. A senior minister in the government, Gupta has been closely associated with efforts to position the state as a major manufacturing, logistics and investment destination.

UP was the fastest-growing major state in number of factories and total factory workers in the five year period from FY19 to FY24.

In an interview with *Business Today*, he discusses how the state government is overseeing policies to

improve ease of doing business, attract capital, and accelerate industrial infrastructure development.

Edited excerpts:

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What kind of trade promotion, business activity, and industrial corridors have come up in the state? What changes are you seeing in business?

UP has emerged as one of the best industrial destinations due to better law and order and ease of doing business. It has attracted top companies and MNCs.

The state's economy has grown from ₹13.30 lakh crore in 2016 to ₹30.80 lakh crore and created job opportunities for more than 37,00,000 individuals. The Prime Minister recently inaugurated the Ganga Expressway and India's largest airport at Jewar. We have a rail network of about 16,000 km. UP is the first state in the country with 16 domestic and five international airports. We have also built the Varanasi-Haldia waterway, which we plan to extend to Ayodhya via the Saryu and Ganga rivers, up to Prayagraj.

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You mentioned ease of doing business and several industrial corridors, including a defence corridor. Can you tell us about the policy and planning behind these?

Along our expressways, we are creating large land banks and have allotted land to many companies, many of which have already started operations. For example, BrahMos. In Kanpur, there is an Adani facility where every bullet carries a barcode, so that if there is a terror incident, we can trace where and when it was made and its full movement. There is also Bharat Dynamics in Jhansi.

And here is something you will be pleased to hear — after 50 years, we are building something bigger than Noida: The Bundelkhand Industrial Development Authority, spread across roughly 60,000 acres between Kanpur and Jhansi, with Jhansi as the main district. It's such a large industrial area that several districts of Madhya Pradesh are being connected to it as well.

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What kind of investment can we expect to see there?

In Lalitpur, we have built a Pharma Park with companies like Sun Pharma, Ranbaxy, and Mankind. We held a conclave for pharma stakeholders—Indian and international—who are keen to set up facilities there. We're building